

Bassaricyon neblina

Olinguito



Location N.W. South America

Length	12–16 in (30–40 cm)
Tail	13 ½–16 ½ in (34–42 cm)
Weight	1 ¾–2 ¼ lb (0.75–1.1 kg)
Social unit	Probably individual
Status	Near threatened



The smallest member of the family Procyonidae is also the most recently identified new species of the order Carnivora. Described in 2013 from museum specimens collected in the Andean cloud forests, the olinguito lives at higher altitudes than its close

cousins the olingos: specimens were collected between 4,921–9,022 ft (1,500–2,750 m). The species is adapted to its cooler montane habitat by having thicker fur; its rich brown coat has hairs that grow up to 4 cm long. It also differs from the more lowland olingos by having furrier ears; a bushier, somewhat shorter, tail; rounder face; and shorter muzzle. Like its tropical American relatives—including the kinkajou—the olinguito occupies the forest canopy, where it is probably active at night, feeding mainly on fruit. A single pair of teats suggests that it has one young at a time. Little is known about the habits of this elusive animal. However, an adult female specimen kept in US zoos during the 1970s has now been identified as an olinguito. It failed to breed with other captive olingos and differed in its vocalizations.

ARBOREAL LIFE
Canopy-dwelling habits doubtless helped the olinguito avoid recognition until the 21st century—even though it is significantly smaller and more richly colored than the better known olingos. Colombian olinguitos have a redder hue, while Ecuadorian animals have black-tipped hairs.



TIGHT GRIP
The olinguito is a superb climber, using its clawed hands and feet to grip branches. But unlike the related kinkajou, its tail is not prehensile.